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Section Title(S): Joking Relationship

Joking Relationship

A very important institution is also linked to the family name. It concerns the ties called "joking relationship," dyo benatye (literally, agreement between us), which is integrated with the general kinship relationships designated in the Mandingo country by the term senānkuya. But family relationships in the strict sense, called sindyi benatye (literally, breast milk between us), are to be distinguished from dyo benatye which, on the contrary, involves the members of two families, or even of two different peoples.

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Thus, a Koulibali is a Kéita's senānku among the Bambara; Bozo and Dogon as well as Bozo and Somono are also senānku(1). To the  120 Mandé, a Koulibali and a Tangara, bound by a long and durable friendship, decided to seal it in a lasting way. They opened their veins and put a little blood from one wound into the other, thus realizing the alliance through this exchange. They next prepared a meal which they ate 84 together while pronouncing their oaths never to spill each other's blood.

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1. Joking relationship called senānkuya among the Bambara is termed māgu among the Dogon, dagana among the Bozo, etc. This important institution, which embraces all the tribes of the French Sudan, has already been the object of a number of studies. See especially: M. Delafosse, Haut-Sénégal Niger /The Upper Senegal and Niger/, Vol. 3, p. 206; H. Labouret, "La Parenté à plaisanteries en Afrique occidentale /Joking Relationship in West Africa/"; D. Paulme, Parenté à plaisanteries et alliance par le sang en Afrique occidentale /Joking Relationship and Blood Alliance in West Africa/; R. Radcliffe-Brown, On Joking Relationships.

In the "Alliance cathartique /The Cathartic Alliance,/" M. Griaule throws light on the Dogon-Bozo relations which are at the origin of the institution in the Sudan. This brings out the fundamental notion of the duality of beings and the principles that animate them. A Dogon and

a Bozo are twins, each carrying a particle of the other in his body and soul. When he insults or purifies, he appeals to that part of himself in the other and the powers he communicates in this way come to the help of his partner.

The latest investigations on this subject have brought to light the following facts: Dogon and Bozo have, respectively, eight seeds and eight fish in their collarbones and thus they realize the distribution of the heavenly sustenance (see p. 53). This latter is evidence of their spiritual integrity and any breaking of taboos results first in depriving the person of his seeds or his fish. The purpose of the institution is to enable the ally to intervene in order to reinstate the nourishing substance in the body of the guilty person.

It should be stated here that in instances in which they are described by the same term (senānkuya), kin relationships, which also involve joking exchanges, must not be confused with relationships between families (more exactly between names) or between tribes.

Moreover, within this last group, several types of alliances can be observed: some involve exogamy (Dogon and Bozo: Bozo and Peul, etc...) others exclude the possibility of carrying out purification rites. It will therefore be necessary to examine as many cases as possible before establishing any rules for this type of alliance.

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